

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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1 Thessalonians 1:1

Ancient letters began with the name of the author, the name of the recipients, and a salutation. • Paul, Silas, and Timothy were the founders of this church ([Acts 17:1-9](#)). • The greeting grace and peace summarizes the believer's experience of the Good News.

1 Thessalonians 1:2

We always thank God for all of you: This is the first of three times the apostle Paul gives thanks for the church (see [2:13](#); [3:9](#)).

1 Thessalonians 1:2-10

After thanking God for the faith, love, and hope of the Thessalonian believers ([1:2-3](#)), Paul recalls how the Good News was proclaimed to them ([1:4-5](#)) and how they accepted its message ([1:6-10](#)). Paul returns to these themes in [2:1-12](#) and [2:13-16](#).

1 Thessalonians 1:3

The reason for Paul's gratitude was the Thessalonians' faithful work, loving deeds, and enduring hope (or *confidence*; see [3:6](#); [5:8](#); [2 Thes 1:3-4](#)).

1 Thessalonians 1:4

dear brothers and sisters: Greek adelphoi, a generic term that refers to members of the same family, both male and female.

1 Thessalonians 1:5

God called the Thessalonians through the proclamation of the Good News ([2 Thes 2:13-14](#)). The Holy Spirit convinced the hearers that the message was true ([1 Cor 2:4-5](#); [1 Pet 1:12](#)).

1 Thessalonians 1:6

Because they accepted the Good News, the Thessalonians experienced severe suffering from their contemporaries ([2:14](#); [3:3-4](#)). Yet as they followed the model of the apostles and of the Lord himself ([Matt 5:11-12](#); [Rom 8:17](#); [12:12](#); [Phil 2:17](#)), they received joy from the Holy Spirit ([1 Pet 4:13-14](#)).

1 Thessalonians 1:7-8

ringing out: The example of the Thessalonians' faith and their proclamation of the Good News was heard throughout the provinces of Macedonia and Achaia.

1 Thessalonians 1:9

Among the Gentiles, the message of the apostles was an exhortation to turn from false idols to serve the living and true God, who created all things ([Acts 14:11-18](#); [17:22-31](#); [19:23-41](#)). In a pluralistic religious environment, the call to forsake ancestral gods was unusual (cp. [Jer 10:8-10](#); [1 Cor 8:4-6](#)).

1 Thessalonians 1:10

The resurrection of Jesus from the dead was the core of the apostles' preaching ([4:14](#); [Acts 2:32](#); [3:15](#); [10:40](#); [13:29-30](#); [1 Cor 15:3-8](#)) and the foundation for confidence in Jesus' return (see [1 Thes 5:9](#); [2 Thes 1:6-10](#)).

1 Thessalonians 2:1

The Greek word translated visit often refers to entry into a city. Ancient orators were known for their grand entrances into a town. Paul's entrance to Thessalonica should be judged by its credible results rather than its lack of pomp or ceremony.

1 Thessalonians 2:1–3:13

The body of this letter begins by discussing Paul's and his associates' character ([2:1–12](#)) and the way the Thessalonians received the Good News ([2:13–16](#)). It then emphasizes Paul's sincere care for the church, telling of his attempts to return to visit them ([2:17–20](#)) and his decision to send Timothy to them when he himself could not come ([3:1–5](#)). Finally, it tells of Paul's joy over Timothy's good report ([3:6–9](#)) and his prayers to get back to the church himself ([3:10–13](#)). This lengthy defense is Paul's response to criticisms of his abrupt departure and prolonged absence.

1 Thessalonians 2:2

Despite the dishonor and pain Paul and Silas had suffered in Philippi ([Acts 16:19–40](#)), they showed courage by preaching confidently in Thessalonica.

1 Thessalonians 2:4

In the ancient world, those entrusted with a public office had to be tested and approved. The Thessalonians ([2:3](#)) and God served as two witnesses to the purity of Paul's motives.

1 Thessalonians 2:5

Flattery was a common means of getting financial gain from others. Paul denies that he flattered the Thessalonians in order to be given money. He again calls both the Thessalonians and God as witnesses (cp. [2:10](#); [Deut 19:15](#); [2 Cor 13:1](#); [1 Tim 5:19](#)).

1 Thessalonians 2:7

we were like children: Some manuscripts read *we were gentle*. Paul and his associates did not wield their apostolic authority to make demands (cp. [Matt 20:25–28](#)).

1 Thessalonians 2:9

Paul and his associates engaged in manual labor to support themselves while in the city (cp. [Acts 18:1–4](#); [1 Cor 9:12–18](#)) as an example to the

Thessalonians ([2 Thes 3:8–9](#)) and to avoid becoming an economic burden to them.

1 Thessalonians 2:10

Both God and the Thessalonians were witnesses (see [2:5](#)) that Paul's conduct was devout and honest, terms used in ancient literature to describe obedience to both divine and human laws.

1 Thessalonians 2:11

In the ancient world, the moral instruction of children was a fundamental obligation of fathers. Roman fathers could be harsh, but Plutarch advised Greek fathers to use praise, reason, exhortations, and good counsel when teaching children to avoid vice and embrace virtue. Paul describes himself as this kind of father to the Thessalonians.

1 Thessalonians 2:12

What God would consider worthy is a life lived in harmony with the high standards he expects of those called ([4:7](#)) to share his Kingdom and glory ([Rom 8:17–18](#); [Col 1:27](#); [2 Thes 2:14](#)).

1 Thessalonians 2:13

Paul gives thanks a second time (see [1:2](#); [3:9](#)) because the Thessalonians accepted the message of the apostles—not just as a human philosophy, but as the very word of God ([1:5](#); [2 Thes 2:14](#); [2 Cor 5:20](#)).

1 Thessalonians 2:14

The evidence that the Thessalonian believers accepted the word of God was that they suffered persecution ([1:6](#)). This followed the pattern of the apostles, the churches in Judea ([Acts 8:1](#)), and Christ himself.

1 Thessalonians 2:15

Paul was not anti-Jewish; out of love for his own people, he prayed for their salvation ([Rom 9:1–5](#);

[10:1](#)). But he was aware of the role some of the Jews had in the deaths of God's messengers, including Jesus ([1 Kgs 19:10](#); [Acts 7:52](#)). Now they had persecuted the apostolic messengers in Thessalonica ([Acts 17:10](#); [2 Cor 11:26](#)).

1 Thessalonians 2:16

The mission to the Gentiles was one of the most important issues in the early church ([Acts 11:18](#); [13:46-49](#); [28:28](#); [Rom 1:16](#)). • Judgment comes when sins pile up to their complete measure ([Gen 15:16](#); [Dan 8:23](#); cp. [Matt 23:31-36](#)).

1 Thessalonians 2:17

separated: Paul describes his unplanned departure from Thessalonica (see [Acts 17:10](#)) as depriving these new believers of their spiritual parents. However, this absence was not neglect. As evidenced by Paul's attempts to return to the church, the separation was unintentional (cp. [Phil 1:7](#); [Col 2:5](#)).

1 Thessalonians 2:18

again and again: Paul made repeated attempts to return to the Thessalonian church. Despite the opposition of Satan (see [Rom 16:20](#); [2 Cor 2:11](#); [Eph 6:10-12](#)), both Timothy ([1 Thes 3:2, 5](#)) and Paul ([Acts 20:1-3](#)) were eventually able to visit the church again.

1 Thessalonians 2:19

In the Greek and Roman world, a crown was given to those who received great civic honor or who were victorious in athletic games.

1 Thessalonians 2:20

Paul views the Thessalonian believers—not his own accomplishments—as the source of his pride, or renown, and his joy ([3:9](#)).

1 Thessalonians 3:1-5

After preaching in Berea, Paul had departed from Macedonia and sailed to Athens, instructing Silas and Timothy to join him soon ([Acts 17:13-15](#)). Timothy returned to Thessalonica ([1 Thes 3:2](#)), as Paul's anxiety for the Thessalonian church had intensified ([3:1, 5](#)).

1 Thessalonians 3:3

we are destined for such troubles: Suffering for the faith is often part of a Christian's life ([1:6](#); [2:14](#); [Phil 1:29](#); [1 Pet 1:6](#); [2:21](#); [3:17](#); [4:19](#)).

1 Thessalonians 3:5

Paul was concerned that Satan, the tempter ([Mark 1:13](#); [1 Cor 7:5](#)), had undermined the Thessalonians' faith ([1 Thes 3:2, 6, 8](#)) and rendered his work among them futile ([Gal 2:2](#); [Phil 2:16](#)).

1 Thessalonians 3:6

Paul wrote 1 Thessalonians from Corinth just after Timothy returned from Thessalonica ([3:2, 5](#); [Acts 18:5](#)). Timothy's report provided good news about the Thessalonians' faith and love, steadfastness ([1 Thes 3:8](#)), and hope (see also [5:8](#); [2 Thes 1:3-4](#)).

1 Thessalonians 3:8

Paul was distressed by his present circumstances ([3:7](#)) and deeply concerned for the church ([3:1, 5](#)). He was relieved to learn that the Thessalonians remained strong and were standing firm in the Lord even though they were also suffering ([2:14](#); [3:3-4](#)).

1 Thessalonians 3:11

Paul's prayer to return to Thessalonica very soon ([3:10](#)) is directed both to the Father and the Lord Jesus, implying Jesus' divinity.

1 Thessalonians 3:12

A characteristic of this church was their love for one another as members of God's family ([4:9](#); [2 Thes 1:3-4](#)). Paul prays that their love will grow and overflow toward those outside the Christian community (cp. [1 Thes 5:15](#); [Gal 6:10](#); [2 Tim 2:24](#); [Titus 3:2](#)) even in the face of persecution.

1 Thessalonians 3:13

In the final part of this prayer ([3:11-13](#)), Paul prays that their hearts—their conduct and moral resolve ([Matt 5:8](#); [Acts 15:9](#); [Heb 10:22](#))—might be strong, blameless, and holy. • When Jesus comes, he will be accompanied by all his holy people, possibly a reference to angels ([Deut 33:2](#); [Ps 89:5, 7](#); [Dan 4:13](#); [8:13](#); [Matt 13:41](#); [Mark 8:38](#); [13:26-27](#); [2 Thes 1:7](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:1-2

we urge you: Paul's exhortation in the name of the Lord Jesus emphasizes the authority of his teaching. • you remember what we taught: Ancient letters frequently included reminders of what the recipients already knew. Paul reminds the Thessalonians of matters that required their obedience ([4:11](#); [2 Thes 3:4](#), [6](#), [10](#), [12](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:1-5.22

The second part of the body of the letter concerns Timothy's news about the church and the questions the believers had for Paul. Paul addresses the problem of sexual immorality ([4:3-8](#)) before responding to the Thessalonians' questions about love for other Christians ([4:9-12](#)), the destiny of believers who have died ([4:13-18](#)), and the timing of the day of the Lord ([5:1-11](#)). Paul takes up a variety of exhortations on topics such as leadership and community relations ([5:12-15](#)), relationship with the Lord ([5:16-18](#)), and prophecy ([5:19-22](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:3

God's will is for you to be holy: The foundation of Christian ethics is not philosophical speculation about virtue but doing God's will ([Rom 12:1-2](#); [Eph](#)

[6:6](#); [Heb 10:36](#); [13:20-21](#)). Holiness ([1 Thes 4:4](#), [7](#)) embraces all of a person's life ([5:23](#)); here it involves staying away from sexual sin (Greek *porneia*, any sexual union outside marriage).

1 Thessalonians 4:4

will control his own body: Self-control brings honor from others ([Rom 12:10](#)) and from God ([Rom 2:7](#); [1 Pet 5:4](#), [6](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:5

Willful ignorance of God and his ways is the root of moral corruption ([Rom 1:18-32](#); [Eph 4:17-18](#)). • lustful passion: Sexual immorality was often tolerated in the Mediterranean world. Prostitution was allowed, but sexual relations with another man's wife were prohibited. Roman marriage customs barred women, but not men, from extramarital affairs. By contrast, Jewish and Christian authors alike prohibited all sexual involvement outside of marriage ([Acts 15:20](#); [1 Cor 6:12-20](#); [Col 3:5-6](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:7

holy . . . not impure: Cp. [1:4](#); [2:12](#); [5:23-24](#); [2 Thes 2:13-14](#); [1 Pet 1:15-16](#).

1 Thessalonians 4:8

Rejecting Paul's teaching on these matters was the same as rejecting God. • The Holy Spirit empowers Christians to live in accord with God's will ([Ezek 36:27](#); [Rom 8:1-4](#); [Gal 5:16](#); [1 Jn 3:24](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:9

God himself has taught you to love one another (cp. [Isa 54:13](#)) through the teaching of Jesus ([John 13:34-35](#)), the cross ([Rom 5:8](#); [Eph 5:1-2](#)), and the Holy Spirit ([Rom 5:5](#); [Gal 5:22](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:9–5:11

Paul responds to a series of questions from the Thessalonians (cp. [1 Cor 7:1](#)) concerning love for one another ([1 Thes 4:9–12](#)), the destiny of deceased believers ([4:13–18](#)), and when the day of the Lord would come ([5:1–11](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:10

The Thessalonian believers demonstrated love toward all the believers in the province of Macedonia (Philippi and Berea; see also [1:7–8](#)) through economic aid (cp. [2 Cor 8:1–5](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:11

To live a quiet life is to be respectable and not cause problems in the community. • working with your hands: Paul had previously instructed through his teaching (see [2 Thes 3:10](#)) and personal example ([2 Thes 3:7–9](#)) that they should earn their own living.

1 Thessalonians 4:12

Self-sufficiency and decorum would win the recognition and respect of people who are not believers (see [Rom 13:13](#); [1 Cor 5:12–13](#); [Col 4:5](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:13

the believers who have died (literally *those who have fallen asleep*; also in [4:14](#)): Sleep was a common euphemism for death in Greek, Jewish, and Christian literature ([Dan 12:2](#); [Matt 27:52](#)). Personal existence continues after death ([Luke 23:40–43](#); [Acts 7:55–60](#); [2 Cor 5:6–10](#); [Phil 1:20–24](#); [Rev 6:9–11](#)); those who have died await the resurrection ([1 Cor 15:23](#)). • grieve like people who have no hope: Ancient letters of comfort exhorted mourners not to be overcome with grief because they could do nothing to avert death. Paul does not prohibit grief (cp. [John 16:6, 20](#); [Phil 2:27](#)) but calls Christian mourners to abandon the kind of grief typical of those who have no hope in God.

1 Thessalonians 4:14

The central Christian creed, that Jesus died and was raised to life again, is the foundation for hope in the face of death, guaranteed by the resurrection of Christ ([1 Cor 15](#)). • God will bring back refers to the resurrection of believers ([1 Thes 4:16](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:15

directly from the Lord: Jesus' own teaching provided the source of Paul's assurance for the Thessalonians (see [Matt 24:29–31, 40–41](#)) • not... ahead: Paul wants the Thessalonians to know that, when the Lord returns, the dead will not be at a disadvantage but will participate equally in the resurrection. • In referring to Jesus' coming, Paul uses a Greek term (*parousia*) commonly used to describe the coming of the emperor to a city with great pomp and celebration (see [1 Thes 4:17](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:16

with the trumpet call of God: God's trumpet will herald the resurrection, just as it previously announced the rescue of Israel ([Zeph 1:16](#); [Zech 9:14](#)). In the future it will announce the gathering of God's chosen people from the "farthest ends of the earth and heaven" ([Matt 24:31](#); cp. [1 Cor 15:52](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:17

to meet: This alludes to the custom of sending an official delegation to greet a visiting dignitary and accompany him as he enters the city ([Matt 25:6, 10](#); [Acts 28:15–16](#)).

1 Thessalonians 4:18

The purpose of Paul's teaching about the end is so believers will encourage each other in the face of death. He is not promoting speculation about the end times.

1 Thessalonians 5:1

Questions such as how and when all this will happen occupied the thoughts of both Jewish and

Christian people ([Dan 12:6](#); [Matt 24:3](#); [Luke 17:20](#); [Acts 1:6](#); [1 Pet 1:10–11](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:2

For you know quite well: Paul reminds them of the teaching they had already received ([3:3–4](#)). • The day of the Lord's return is the time when God will come to judge humanity ([Isa 13:6](#), [9](#); [Ezek 30:3](#)) and save his people ([Joel 2:21–32](#); [3:18](#); [Zech 14](#)). • like a thief in the night: Cp. [Matt 24:43–44](#); [Luke 12:39–40](#); [2 Pet 3:10](#); [Rev 3:3](#); [16:15](#).

1 Thessalonians 5:3

"Everything is peaceful and secure": The expression "peace and safety" was common during the era of the *pax Romana* (Roman peace). Amid such presumed security, God's ultimate judgment comes without warning and is inescapable.

1 Thessalonians 5:4

The day of the Lord will not surprise believers—not because they know the date of his coming, but because they are spiritually prepared.

1 Thessalonians 5:5

As children of the light, the Thessalonian believers were saved from darkness ([John 12:36](#); [Acts 26:18](#); [Eph 5:8](#); [1 Pet 2:9](#)). • of the day: They belong to God's new order ([Rom 13:12](#)). • darkness and night: These refer to an immoral life (see [1 Thes 5:6–8](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:6

Stay alert and be clearheaded echoes Jesus' call to be morally prepared because the disciples will not know the day of his return ([Matt 24:42](#), [44](#); [25:13](#); cp. [1 Pet 1:13](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:7

Sleep refers to moral indifference ([5:6](#)), and drunk is a metaphor for those who do not exercise self-

control; they will be surprised by the day of the Lord ([5:4](#); [Matt 24:48–51](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:8

Armor . . . helmet ([Isa 59:17](#); [Eph 6:11–17](#)): The armament is the moral life ([Rom 13:12](#); [2 Cor 6:7](#); [10:3–5](#); [2 Tim 2:3–4](#)). The Christian soldier is equipped with the virtues of faith, love, and confidence (see [1 Thes 1:3](#); [3:6](#); [1 Cor 13:13](#); [2 Thes 1:3–4](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:9

God's anger ([1:10](#); [2:16](#); [Rom 5:9](#); cp. [2 Thes 1:6–10](#); [2:8](#)) represents the carrying out of his judgment against evil. However, God destined believers for salvation, not wrath ([2 Thes 2:13–14](#)), and they will escape the terrors of the day of the Lord ([1 Thes 5:1–3](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:10

The promise that believers will live with him forever is based on Christ's resurrection ([4:14](#)). • dead or alive: A reference to living and deceased believers ([4:13–15](#)) rather than people's moral condition (as in [5:6–7](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:11

Paul wants the Thessalonians to use the instruction about the end to encourage and build each other up (see [4:18](#)), not to fuel speculation about the timing of the Lord's return.

1 Thessalonians 5:12

honor (or *know*): This may be a call either to honor church leaders or to recognize the emerging leaders in the church ([1 Cor 16:15–16](#)). True leaders . . . work hard ([1 Tim 4:10](#); [5:17](#)) and govern to serve ([Matt 20:25–28](#)). They preside over, as well as help and protect, the church ([Rom 16:1–2](#); [1 Tim 3:4–5](#), [12](#)). • give you spiritual guidance: Leaders correct both moral and doctrinal errors ([Acts 20:31](#); [1 Cor 4:14](#); [Col 1:28](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:13

Leaders were to receive honor and love not because of their high position but because of their work. • live peacefully: Teaching about community peace and harmony was a standard topic in ancient moral instruction. Harmony between believers and leaders was especially important because of the persecution the church suffered ([2:14](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:14

The responsibility for the moral progress of the congregation does not rest solely with the leaders ([4:18](#); [5:11](#)). Paul urged the church to warn those who are lazy, that is, those who were “disorderly,” and who did not live by the apostles’ instructions (see [2 Thes 3:6-15](#)). • Take tender care of those who are weak, or those who have no economic or social power. Greek society denigrated the weak. • Instead of being irritable, believers should be patient in their relationships ([Gal 5:23](#); [Eph 4:2](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:15

Jesus and the apostles warned against retaliation ([Matt 5:38-48](#); [Luke 6:27-36](#); [Rom 12:17-21](#); [1 Pet 3:9](#)). The Roman author Seneca, by contrast, considered revenge legitimate and necessary as a way of restoring social honor lost because of ill treatment from others. Paul calls Christians to do good—both to members of the church (each other) and to those outside the Christian community (to all people), including their persecutors ([1 Thes 2:14](#); see [3:12](#); [Gal 6:10](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:17

Never stop praying means not giving up ([1:2](#); [Luke 18:1](#); [Rom 12:12](#); [Eph 6:18](#)); it does not mean praying at every moment.

1 Thessalonians 5:18

Be thankful: God is sovereign and can redeem any situation ([Rom 8:28](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:19

Do not stifle the Holy Spirit: Paul exhorts the Thessalonian believers not to put out the Spirit’s fire ([Matt 3:11](#); [Acts 2:3](#); [2 Tim 1:6](#)) by prohibiting prophecy in the church ([Jer 20:9](#); [1 Jn 4:1-2](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:20-21

Prophecy, meant to build up the church ([1 Cor 14:1-4](#)), should not be rejected. Instead, the Thessalonians should test the prophecies ([1 Cor 12:10](#); [14:29](#)) to discern their origin, to check their agreement with the teaching of the apostles ([2 Thes 2:2](#); [1 Jn 4:1-3](#)), and to gauge the character of those who utter them ([Matt 7:15-20](#)). Early Christian teaching said, “Not everyone who speaks about spiritual things is a prophet, but only if the person’s conduct is like the Lord” (*Didache* 11:8). They should hold on to what is good—namely, prophecies that have been tested and found to be genuine.

1 Thessalonians 5:22

They should reject every kind of evil, especially false prophecies ([5:19-21](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:23

God enables Christians to live a holy life ([3:11-13](#)). His sanctifying work extends to the spirit and soul and body, the totality of human life (cp. [Matt 10:28](#); [Mark 12:30](#); [1 Cor 7:34](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:23-28

Greek and Roman letters ended with a wish for the good health of the recipient. Jewish letters concluded with a peace blessing. Paul closes with a Christian variation on these practices.

1 Thessalonians 5:24

God will make this happen: Paul bases his confidence on the faithful character of God ([1 Cor 1:9](#); [2 Thes 3:3](#); [2 Tim 2:13](#); [1 Jn 1:9](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:26

a sacred kiss (see also [Rom 16:16](#); [1 Cor 16:20](#); [2 Cor 13:12](#); [1 Pet 5:14](#)): Kissing on the cheek or forehead was a common form of greeting that reflected such sentiments as honor, friendship, and love among family members ([Mark 14:44-45](#); [Luke 7:36-47](#); [15:20](#); [Acts 20:37](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:27

read this letter: Public reading of Scripture was practiced in both the synagogue ([Luke 4:16](#); [Acts 13:15](#)) and the church ([1 Tim 4:13](#)). Similarly, Paul's letters were to be read aloud to the whole congregation ([Col 4:16](#)).

1 Thessalonians 5:28

Paul improves the customary greeting by adding a blessing of grace at the end of his correspondence ([Rom 16:20](#); [1 Cor 16:23](#); [Gal 6:18](#); [Eph 6:24](#); [2 Thes 3:18](#)).